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Hunger at new heights in Mass.

Study finds 40% of households face food insecurity

By Janelle Nanos
GLOBE STAFF

As prices continue to climb on everything from gas to energy to groceries, a record 40 percent of Massachusetts households are now reporting food insecurity, according to a new study from the Greater Boston Food Bank and Mass General Brigham.

The report found that 1.12 million households didn't have reliable access to food last year, a rate that's up from 37 percent in 2024, and more than double pre-pandemic levels.

"It's been a very difficult year for people across the Commonwealth," said Catherine D'Amato, president and chief executive of the Greater Boston Food Bank, which partners with 600 agencies across 190 towns in New England and serves 600,000 people each month.

D'Amato cited a "cascade" of factors contributing to this most recent uptick: persistent inflation, rising housing costs, and "a

HUNGER, Page A10

Smaller IRS still pressured by Trump

By Julian E.J. Sorapuru
GLOBE STAFF

WASHINGTON — Since President Trump reclaimed office, the Internal Revenue Service has shed about one-quarter of its workforce. The "Big, Beautiful Bill" introduced new complexities to the tax code. And the federal agency has had seven different leaders, but is currently without a commissioner confirmed by the Senate.

Amid all this upheaval and with the April 15 filing deadline approaching, the president is expecting the IRS to deliver a big win for his affordability agenda: large tax refunds for everyday Americans.

So far, the IRS seems to be taking the pressure in stride.

According to agency data, the average refund amount thus far this filing season is \$3,571, up about \$400 compared to last year. What's more, 80 percent of federal refunds have been issued promptly, in less than three weeks.

But some IRS experts said Trump's changes to the agency could have adverse effects on the millions of Americans with com-

TAXES, Page A7

Trump backs off, OK's cease-fire



MAJID SAEEDI/GETTY IMAGES

People inspected the damage after Sharif University of Technology in Tehran was hit by US-Israeli attacks.

Had threatened 'whole civilization will die' with strikes; Iran says it will allow passage through strait for 2 weeks

By Bassem Mroue, Jon Gambrell, and Samy Magdy
ASSOCIATED PRESS

TEHRAN — President Trump pulled back on his threats to launch devastating strikes on Iran late Tuesday, swerving to deescalate the war less than two hours before the deadline he set for Tehran to capitulate to a deal.

Trump said he was holding off on his threatened attacks on Iranian bridges and power plants, as the United States and Iran agreed to a two-week cease-fire that includes the re-

opening of the Strait of Hormuz.

Iran's Supreme National Security Council said that it has accepted the cease-fire and that it would negotiate with the United States in Islamabad beginning Friday. Neither Iran nor the United States said when the cease-fire would begin, and attacks took place in Israel, Iran, and across the Gulf region early Wednesday.

Israel has also agreed to the cease-fire, according to a White House official who was not authorized to comment publicly and spoke on condition of ano-

nymity. The cease-fire calls for Israel and Hezbollah to halt fighting in Lebanon, according to the prime minister of Pakistan, which has been mediating talks.

In the version of its 10-point plan released in Farsi, Iran included the phrase "acceptance of enrichment" for its nuclear program. But for reasons that remain unclear, that phrase was missing in English versions shared by Iranian diplomats to journalists.

Trump initially had said Iran proposed a "workable" 10-

IRAN, Page A6



NASA/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

DOUBLE VISION

A photo released Tuesday showed Earth dipping beneath the moon's horizon as seen from Artemis II, one of many impressive pictures taken by four astronauts in their lunar flyby. The four went well beyond technical language to express awe and excitement. "It was hard to speak," Victor Glover, the pilot, told mission control. **A2.**

JPMorgan just the latest to sign up for a spot on the skyline

By Catherine Carlock
GLOBE STAFF

In a city known for its parochial nature — not to mention a wariness that sometimes borders on antagonism toward outsiders — the name that could soon be emblazoned across Boston's newest skyscraper might cause some clucks among the chattering class.

JPMorganChase & Co., the New York-based banking behemoth, is in negotiations to place its brand atop the 690-foot-tall South Station Tower when it opens an office there in 2028. If it succeeds, JPMorgan would join Verizon, State Street, and CarGurus among

companies whose names bedeck some of the city's newest buildings.

City Hall has been open to allowing more signs atop towers, a notable shift that has animated social media gadflies and corporate brand types alike, and a far cry from the days when the Prudential Tower and the Citgo sign had the skyline largely to themselves.

"What we're seeing with Mayor [Michelle] Wu . . . is an acceptance to really brand Boston as the hub," said Cory dePasquale, who leads signage and wayfinding for global design firm Selbert Perkins in Belmont.

The Wu administration is moderniz-

ing the city's rules on signs of all sizes and locations, contained in a 35-page document that encompasses 22 different zoning regulations. Permitting even small signs close to the ground takes, on average, 4½ months, and sometimes longer.

In March, the Boston Planning Department unveiled draft changes that aim to streamline the process and make about 80 percent of signs permitted by right — meaning they would not need a zoning change.

That's for signs lower to street level, however. Anything at or above a building's fourth story, such as the JPMor-

gan sign, would still need to be reviewed by several city groups.

In JPMorgan's case, the city granted provisional design approval in the fall, a spokesperson for the Boston Planning Department said. Next, planners will review design, construction documents, shop drawings, and lighting. Then the Inspectional Services Department would need to issue a building permit.

If that seems like a lengthy process, consider that South Station Tower has been in the works for more than three decades, and given Boston's prolonged

SIGNS, Page A10

A touching farewell to a gentle presence at farm



JOHN TLUMACKI/GLOBE STAFF

Lyla Landsberg wrote words for Curtis, a Highland steer.

By Lindsay Crudele
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Curtis and Willard, a pair of Highland steers, were an unlikely sight, two looming, shaggy sentinels roaming the pastures along Brookline's Allandale Road. Since 2008, the Vermont transplants lived at historic urban garden center Allandale Farm, and had many friends in those who visited, especially children.

Willard died about a year ago under the weight of years and his own massive body, and in January, so went his brother Curtis. On Saturday, about 75 mourners, many of them very young, gathered to celebrate Curtis with a proper Scottish send-off. As bagpipes wound through the crisp April air, it felt like many a Boston funeral. And though the deceased was

bovine, the grief shared around the bonfire was quite human.

Mourners recalled the contradiction between Curtis's heft and horns, and his sleepy, gentle nature. He was beloved by the smallest children who enjoyed feeding him apples and fearlessly petting his nose.

As deaths can mark the passage of time as much as the memory of the deceased, the memorial felt like the end of an era for many families who saw Allandale's steers as a centerpiece of farm visits. Younger regular visitors had never known the farm without Curtis and Willard. Sighs and sniffles could be heard, while Jack MacLean, a bagpiper for 57 years, performed in tartan by the bonnie banks of Allandale's frog pond. Listening to tributes,

STEER, Page B4

BU is pausing its removal of Pride flags from campus offices amid a national backlash. **B1.**

Lindsay Clancy would admit to killing her three children if a judge agrees to split her upcoming trial. **B1.**

HubSpot is re-branding its celebrity-and-marketing conference. **B5.**

Devra First finds herself coming around on a New England institution: Dunkin'. **G1.**



Apply another coat

Wednesday: Sunny, chilly. High 39-44. Low 30-35.

Thursday: Better. High 50-55. Low 34-39. Sunrise: 6:15 Sunset: 7:18

Weather and Comics, G6-7.

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